

household. Before the FIRE blogs, my wife and I gave freely to charities and other causes we believed in. Now I acted judgmentally. Was this organization as effective and efficient as we were with our money? Would that person use our gift wisely or just waste it? How could we justify giving away our hard-earned money when saving it would allow us to retire sooner? We took similar approaches with our personal spending, tightly holding on to every dollar. We began to do less of the things that had always made us happy.

Rather than gaining the freedom I desired, I led myself into a different trap. I was trying to live up to what I believed to be other people's values and expectations rather than being true to my own.

Hitting these potholes is common for many of us who *Choose FI*. I finally realized that I needed to figure out what I truly wanted in life. I needed to develop my own personal blueprint for building that life. I needed to learn that money is a very powerful tool that can provide many things, but it is always just a means to an end and never the end itself. This sent me on a mission of discovery, looking for truth.

I began questioning everything and reading voraciously, from technical aspects of personal finance to finding personal happiness, fulfillment, and purpose. I accumulated different lessons and truths